working on propulsion systems for Centre national d'études spatiale (CNES), the French space agency, which was a member of the European Space Agency (ESA). In the early 1970s, Sarabhai wanted me to go to Paris and explore the possibilities of a tie-up from which we could learn more on solid propulsion.

SEP had its solid propulsion centre in Istres and a liquid propulsion system centre in Vernon. Its Boardeaux facility dealt with control rockets and some defence-related development; SEP also had a cryogenic lab in Villaroche. Understandably, I was eyeing a joint venture with the Vernon centre.

P Souffle, a retired French army officer, was the chairman and managing director of SEP, and Rene Morin was the commercial director. The two gentlemen were cordial to me and Nandakumar, my deputy on the electronics side. SEP wasn't convinced about the capabilities of Indian space engineers in developing high-end rocket engines, but was keen on doing business with India. We did not want to buy rockets from them, and hence there was no deal in sight. There had to be a way out. And that is when I bumped into Kanwal Grover.

Nandakumar and I were at Le Lido, the most famous address of entertainment on Champs-Elysees, Paris. Champagne flowed at the night club where the high and mighty rubbed shoulders amidst cabaret and burlesque. Suddenly, the music stopped and the manager of the club came on the microphone.

'We have a distinguished guest from India. Ladies and gentlemen, let's welcome Mr Kanwal Grover,' came the announcement.

A smiling, balding gentleman stepped on to the stage, took the microphone and thanked everyone. And then he announced that he was ordering half a bottle of champagne for every guest that night. The crowd went into a rapturous applause; I remained dumbstruck thinking who this wealthy Indian was. The guests, like us, had paid 250 Francs for an entry into the club, and got half a bottle of champagne on the house.

Grover was soon to impress me more as a businessman of rare acumen and a sense of selflessness that only patriotism can infuse in a man. He was